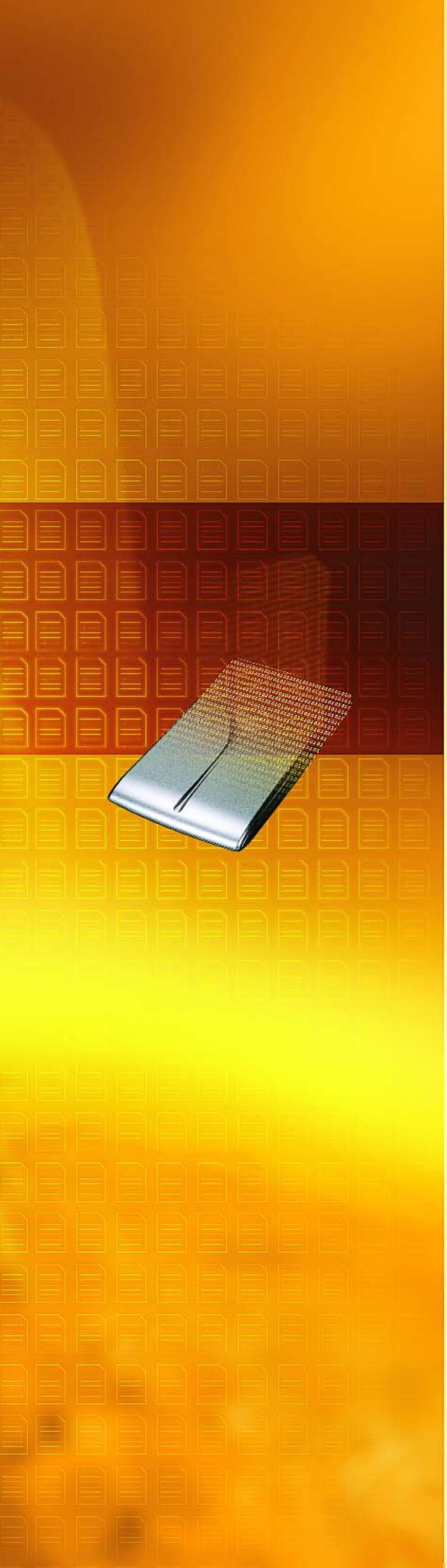

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We go about our daily work communicating, documenting and in the end, produce results.

Software is replaceable, but the data you've generated putting in personal effort isn't. You stand to lose hundreds or thousands of hours of work if you do not have a backup solution in place.

There are various backup solutions to choose from—the one you choose depends on your requirements. The most affordable ones are CD or DVD burners, and internal hard disk drives—perhaps in a RAID setup—followed by external hard drives, tape drives, etc. Then there are online backup solutions provided by Web sites such as XDrive and IBackup, which are convenient since there is no physical medium that you need to safeguard. Unfortunately, online backup solutions are yet to make their presence felt in India, as they, naturally, rely heavily on broadband access.

CD or DVD burners are affordable, and so are the media they use. They are not the most convenient though, as they require you to sit down and burn disk after disk. Backing up is an important part of office work, but you do not want it taking up an entire day of your working week!

A quicker option is an external hard drive. You can get an external drive with a capacity that matches or exceeds that of your workstation or server hard drive(s). Making a complete disk mirror takes a short while and almost no effort after the initial configuration and software setup. The biggest advantage that external hard drives bring is data portability.

This hardware test takes a look at currently available backup solutions: DVD burners and external hard drives. We divided DVD burners into three categories: single-layer burners, dual-layer burners, and external burners. The external hard disk drives were categorised according to size. It's up to you to pick a solution to suit your need.

DVD WRITERS

For this test, we received 23 DVD burners from 13 different vendors. Of our three categories: Single-layer DVD writers, dual-layer DVD writers and external DVD writers—the maximum number of drives were single-layer, internal DVD writers.

We were glad to see eight drives from seven different vendors with dual-layer DVD-writing support. This showcases the speed with which technology is adopted. Dual-layer writing support was also seen in external DVD burners of IOmega. Availability of optical DVD media—especially dual-layer—is currently an issue, but this too shall pass with time.

Single-layer DVD Writers

Single-layer DVD burners can burn up to 4.3 GB of data onto single-layer DVD media. By current CD standards, 4.3 GB is large indeed. A typical SoHo workstation is likely to have 40 or 60 GB of disk space, a complete backup of which will fit on just 10 to 15 single-layer DVDs. Besides, the cost per MB for single-layer media has dropped enough to rival that of CDs. Add to this the convenience offered by DVDs, and they seem even more attractive. Of course, a dual-layer burner means higher capacities, but lower-cost single-layer disks are sufficient for most scenarios.

In this category, we had one drive each from Sony, ASUS, Gigabyte, Samsung, AOpen, and Krypton; two from Plextor; and three from Lite-On. All, except the AOpen, were capable of burning to both DVD+R and DVD-R. The AOpen only supports DVD+R. Even Pioneer, the pushers of the DVD-R format, offers full DVD+R compatibility with their drives.

Features

The two Plextor burners we tested—the PX-708A and the PX-712A, at 8X and 12X respectively—offer a winning set of features: Mt Rainier support—which is the new standard in packet writing technology, designed to do away with specific software such as InCD and Direct-To-Disk; excellent build quality; and a generous 8 MB of buffer memory in the 12X variant. Since the other drives offer only 2 MB, Plextor's 12X model performed well.